temples were places of public worship and not the property of the Brahmins who ran them. Accordingly, under the Religious Endowments Act of 1863 all control of temple properties and revenues passed to temple boards made up of government-appointed trustees overseeing local committees of temple appointees. This secular control was further strengthened in 1923 by the setting up of Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments Boards, each made up of a president and commissioners nominated by government. After Independence each state within the Indian Union further extended this policy, so that today no religious leaders are directly involved in temple management. It was only at this post-Independence stage that state governments felt sufficiently empowered to appropriate temple assets, chiefly in the form of land.

As for the Chidambaram temple, the presiding priests there have always been Podu Dikshitars, a Brahmin sub-caste who only marry among themselves and are found nowhere else in Tamil Nadu. It is greatly to their credit that they were among the first Brahmins to open their temple doors to all Hindus irrespective of caste. Indeed, the Chidambaram temple is one of the few Shaiva temples in South India that allows access to non-Hindus to all but the innermost temple precinct. However, it is equally a fact that no inventory of the temple's treasures was ever produced to the authorities. From the 1920s onwards scores of Chola bronzes began appearing on the market as art collectors and foreign museums began to appreciate their inspired artistry – and their value. The very finest of these were the Nataraja Shiva bronzes, many of which are believed to have been associated with the Chidambaram temple, as related earlier. Reader, you must draw your own conclusions as to how such treasures came on to the market.

I could list many more instances of such revisionism, some trivial and others rather more serious. The two examples I have cited both happen to involve South Indian